

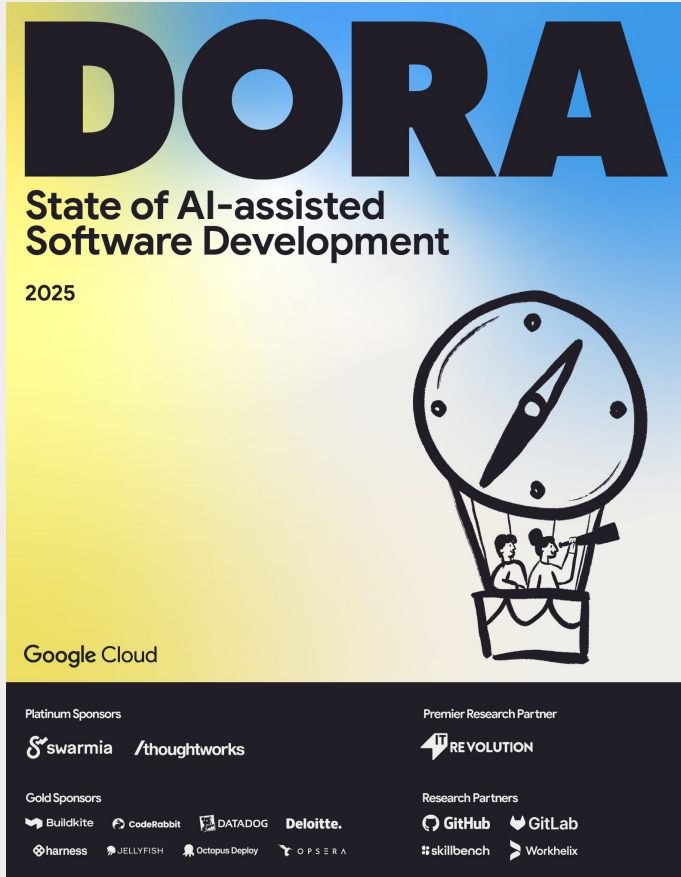


State of AI-assisted Software Development

From local productivity to
systemic success

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(some of the) Research team

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Derek DeBellis



Kevin M. Storer, Ph.D.



Nathen Harvey



Eirini Kalliamvakou, Ph.D.



Gene Kim



Matt Beane, Ph.D.



Daniel Rock, Ph.D.



Jessie Young



Steve Yegge



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BUSINESS INSIDER

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Ana Altchek

Tue, September 23, 2025 at 7:10 AM PDT · 4 min read

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1

The platform behaves in a way I
would expect.

infrastructure.



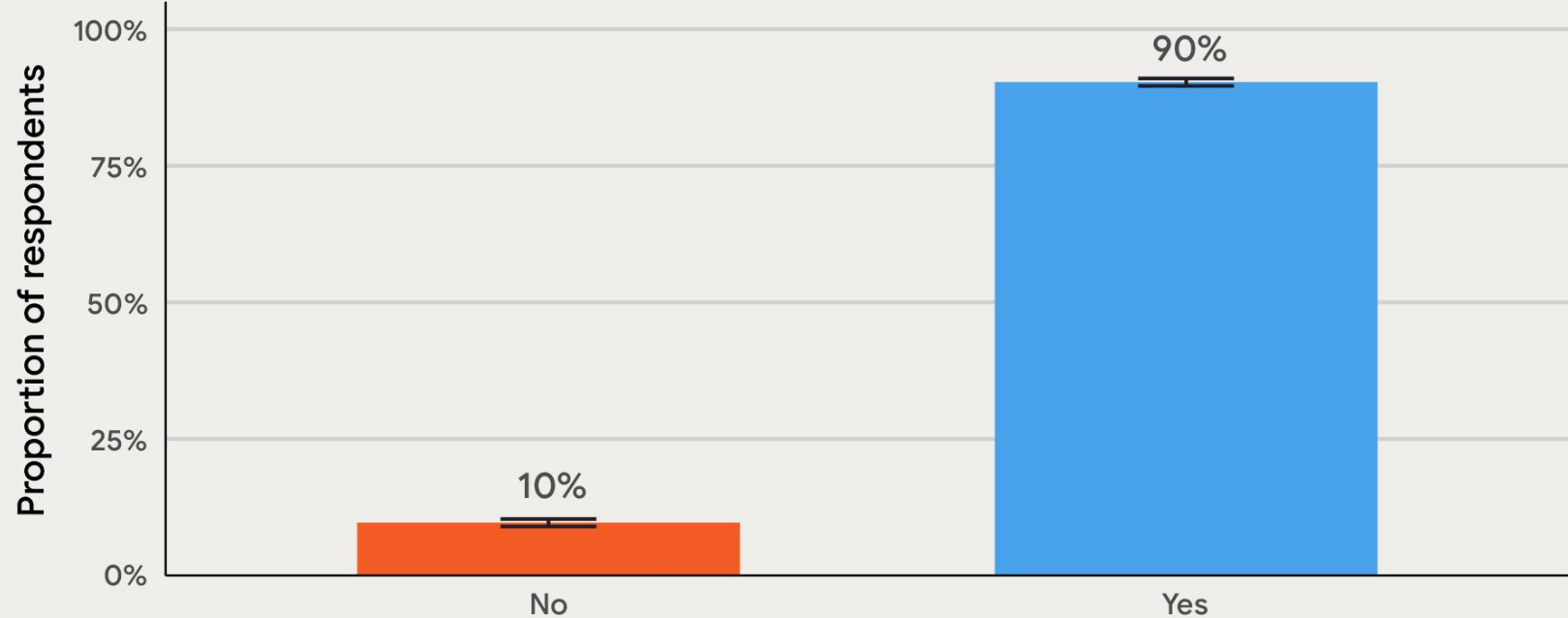
“We learned that AI is most effective when it augments the skills of talented engineers. By automating the tedious, repetitive tasks, AI freed up our developers to focus on strategic problem-solving and innovation.”

**AI's primary role in
software
development is that
of an amplifier**

**DO
RA**

AI adoption

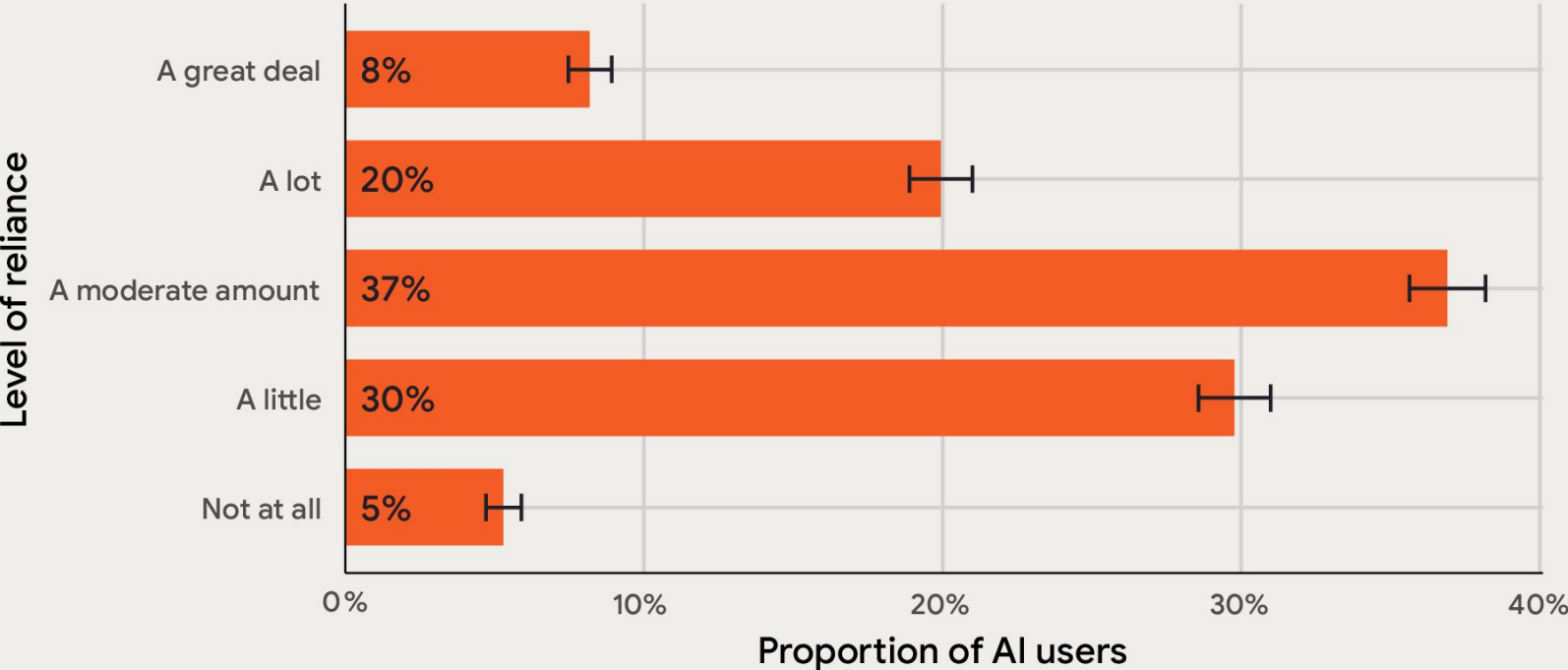
Proportion of respondents who use AI at work



Error bars show the 89% credible interval.

General reliance on AI at work

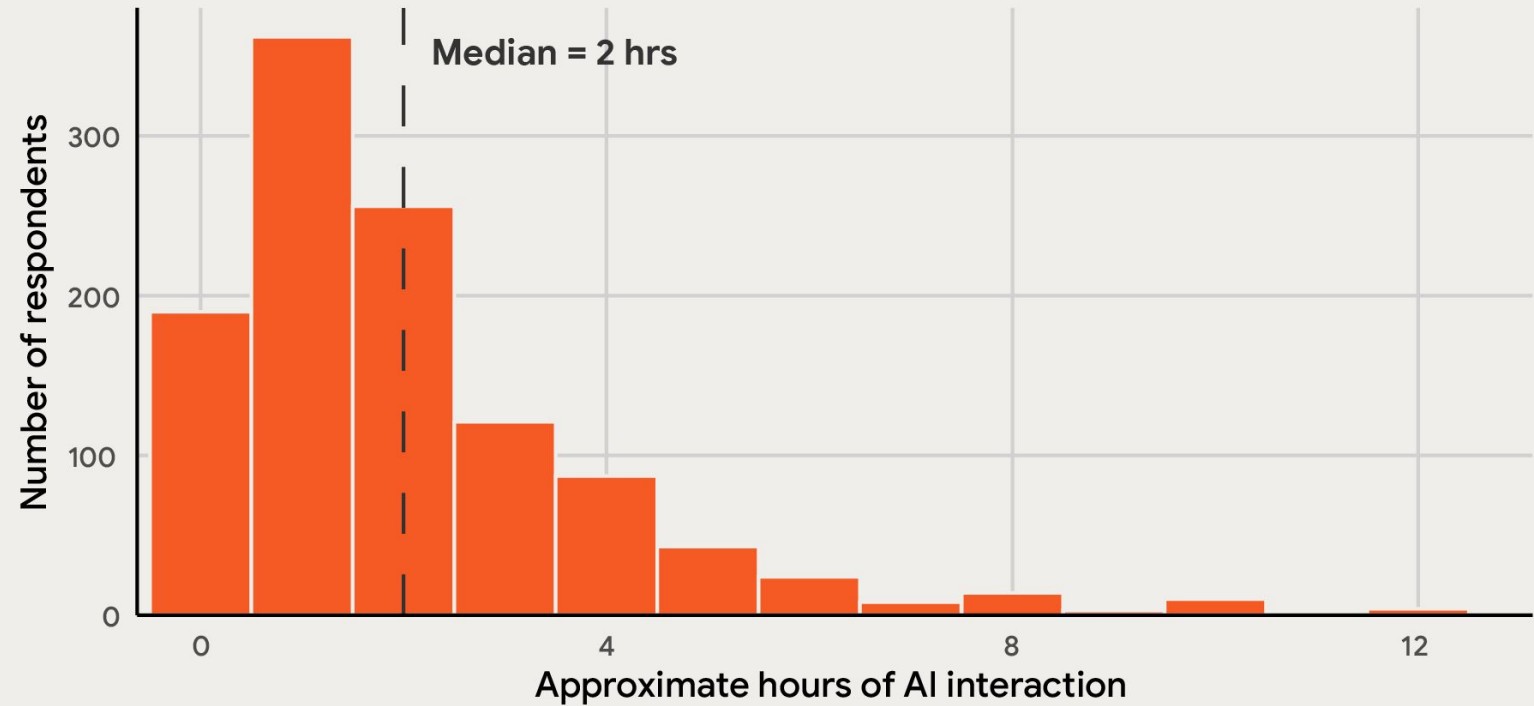
Distribution of reliance levels among AI users



Error bars show the 89% credible interval.

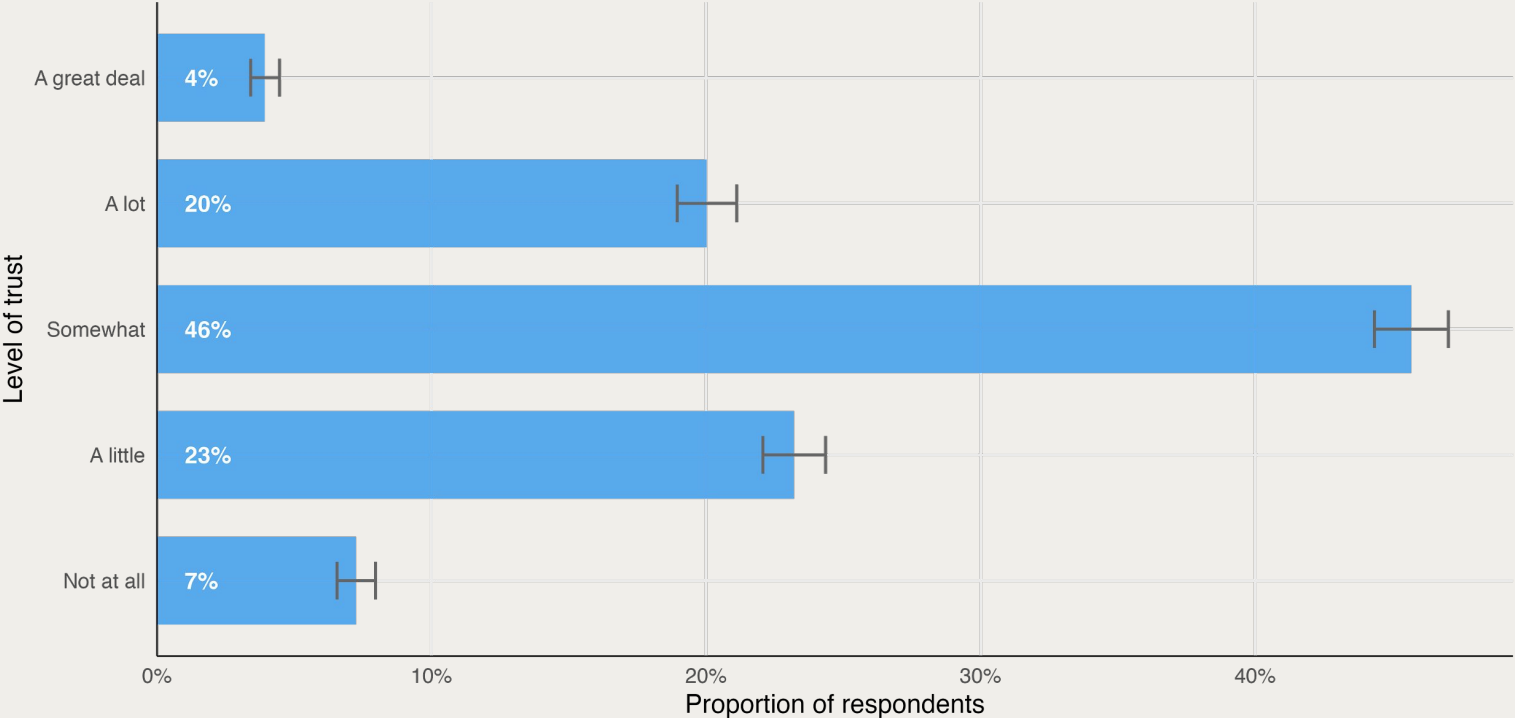
Time spent using AI on a recent workday

Distribution of daily interaction time among AI users



Trust in the quality of AI-generated output

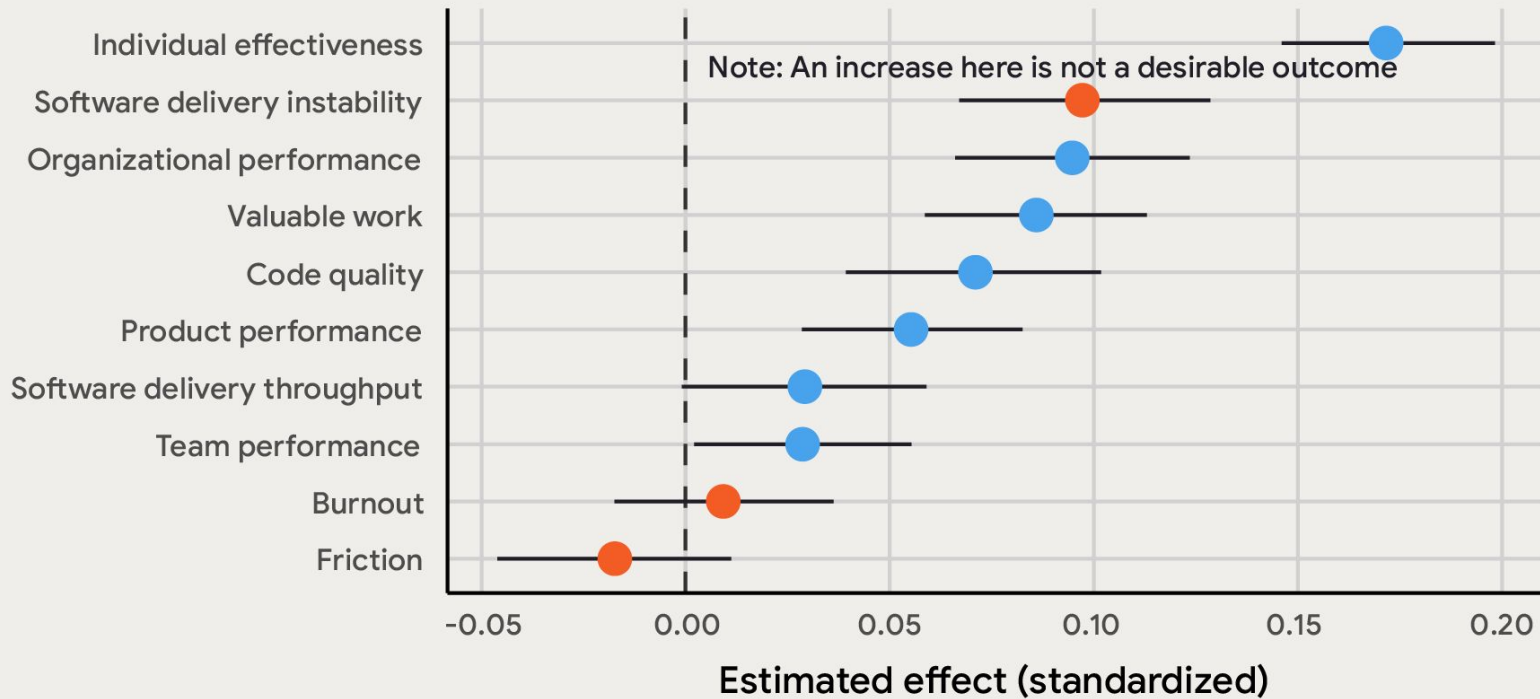
Distribution of trust levels among respondents



Error bars show the 89% credible interval.

AI's impact

Estimated effect of AI adoption on key outcomes, with 89% credible intervals



For outcomes in orange (e.g., Burnout), a negative effect is desirable.

When compared to 2024...

Consistent beneficial effects

- individual effectiveness
- code quality
- team performance
- organizational performance

Consistent stubborn effects

- no relationship with friction
- no relationship with burnout
- An increase in software delivery instability

Changes for the better

- Valuable time: negative → positive
- Delivery throughput: negative → positive
- Product performance: neutral → positive

**Reflecting and
amplifying
organizational
capabilities**

**DO
RA**

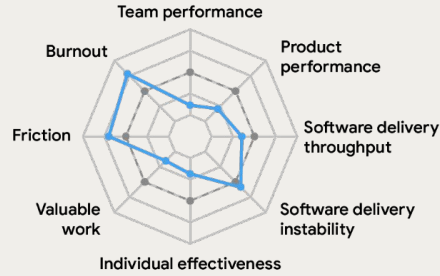
Look beyond software delivery performance

- Team performance
- Product performance
- Software delivery throughput
- Software delivery instability
- Individual effectiveness
- Time doing valuable work
- Friction
- Burnout

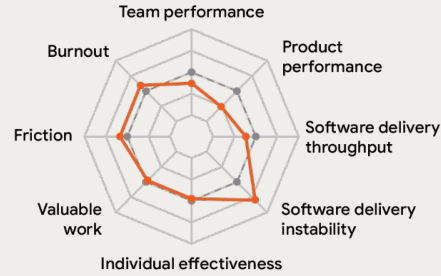
Seven unique team profiles

1. Foundational challenges
2. Legacy bottleneck
3. Constrained by process
4. High impact, low cadence
5. Stable and methodical
6. Pragmatic performers
7. Harmonious high-achievers

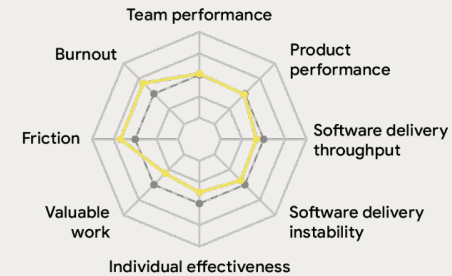
Cluster 1:
Foundational challenges



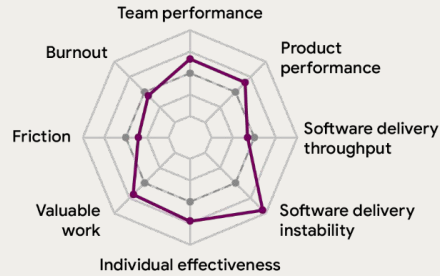
Cluster 2:
The legacy bottleneck



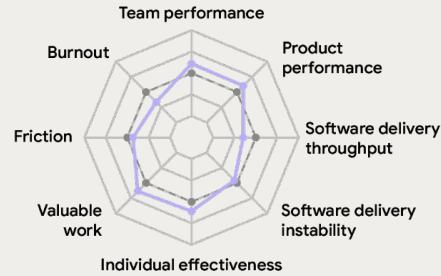
Cluster 3:
Constrained by process



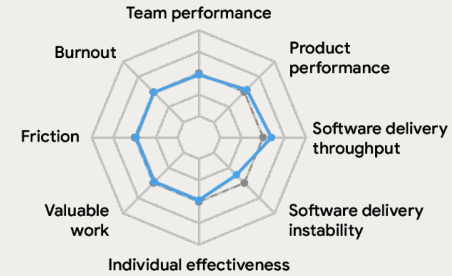
Cluster 4:
High impact, low cadence



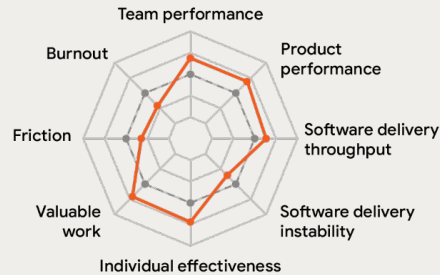
Cluster 5:
Stable and methodical



Cluster 6:
Pragmatic performers



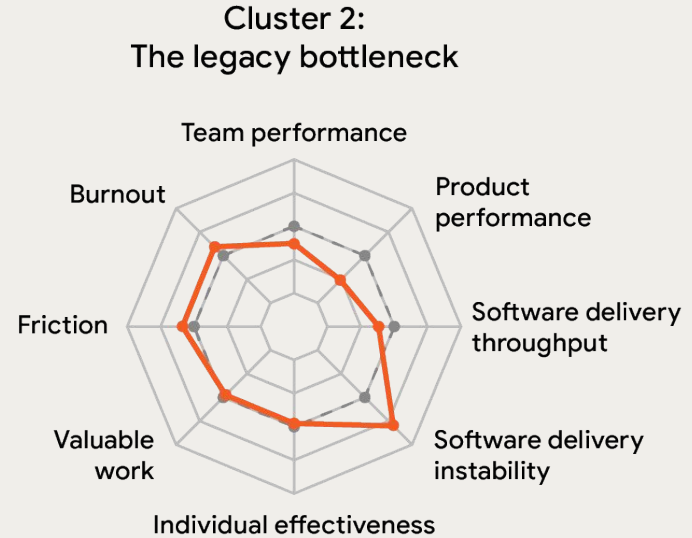
Cluster 7:
Harmonious high-achiever



Legacy bottleneck

Teams are in a constant state of reaction, where unstable systems dictate their work and undermine their morale.

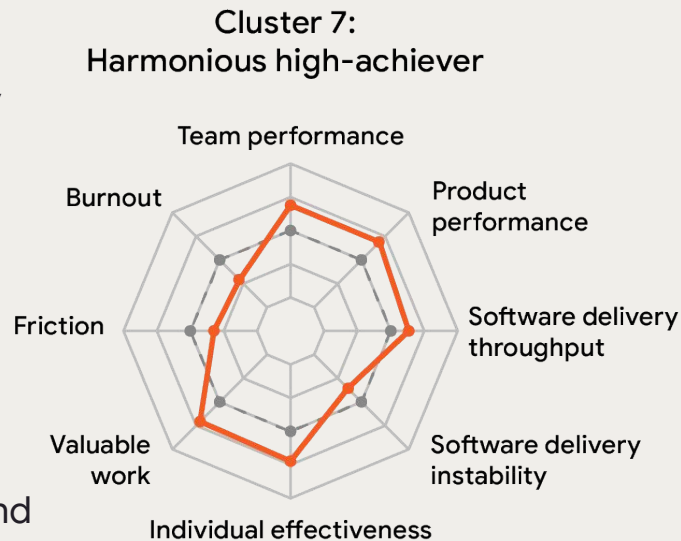
- 11% of respondents
- Product performance is low. While the team delivers regular updates, the value realized is diminished by ongoing quality issues.
- Elevated levels of friction and burnout.
- Significant and frequent challenges with the stability of the software and its operational environment, leading to a high volume of unplanned, reactive work.



Harmonious high-achievers

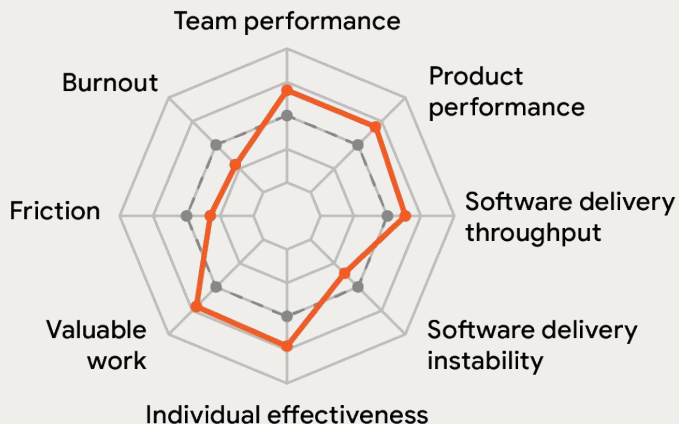
A virtuous cycle where a stable, low-friction environment empowers teams to deliver high-quality work sustainably and without burnout.

- 20% of respondents
- Positive metrics across multiple areas, including team well-being, product outcomes, and software delivery.
- Work environment is characterized by low reported levels of burnout and friction.
- A stable technical foundation that supports both the speed and quality of their work.

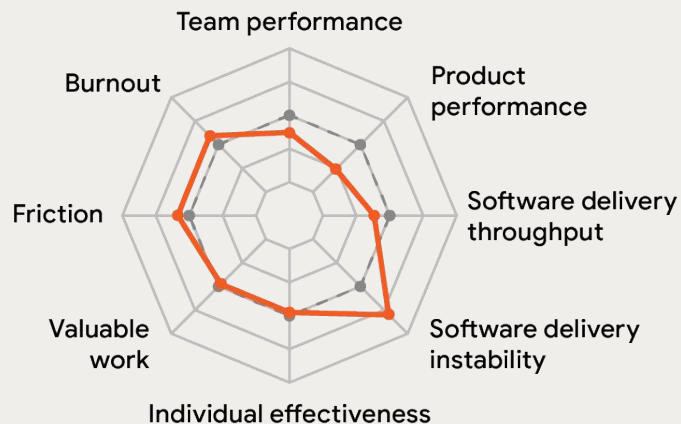


Side-by-side comparison

Cluster 7:
Harmonious high-achiever



Cluster 2:
The legacy bottleneck





DORA AI
capabilities
model

DORA AI capabilities

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Clear and
communicated
AI stance



Healthy data
ecosystems



AI-accessible
internal data



Strong version
control practices



Working in
small batches

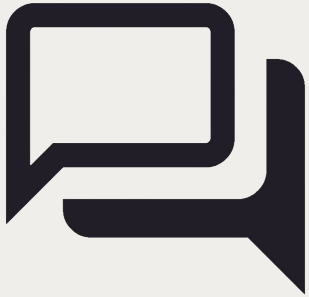


User-centric
focus



Quality
internal
platforms

Clear and communicated AI stance



The comprehensibility and awareness of an organization's official position on how their developers are expected and permitted to use AI-assisted development tools.

- Increased individual effectiveness
- Increased team performance
- Increased organizational performance
- Reduced friction
- Increased software delivery throughput

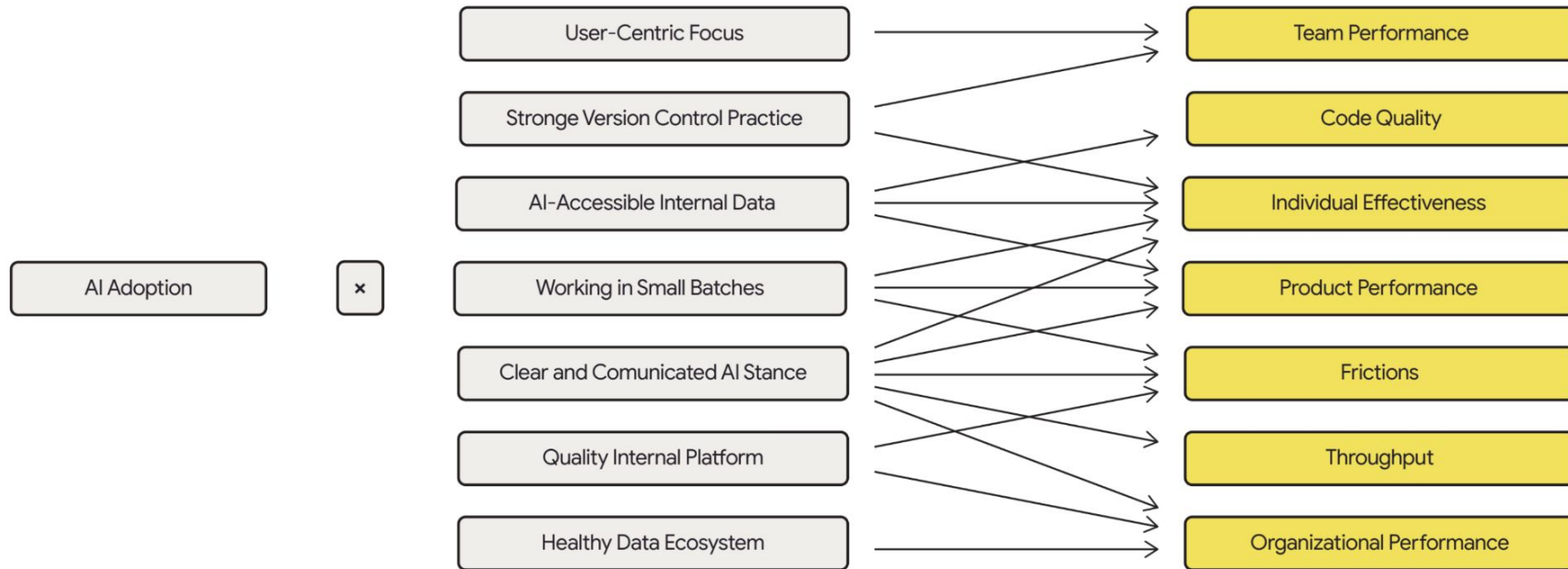
Working in small batches



The degree to which teams break down their changes into manageable units that can be quickly tested and evaluated.

- Increased product performance
- Reduced friction

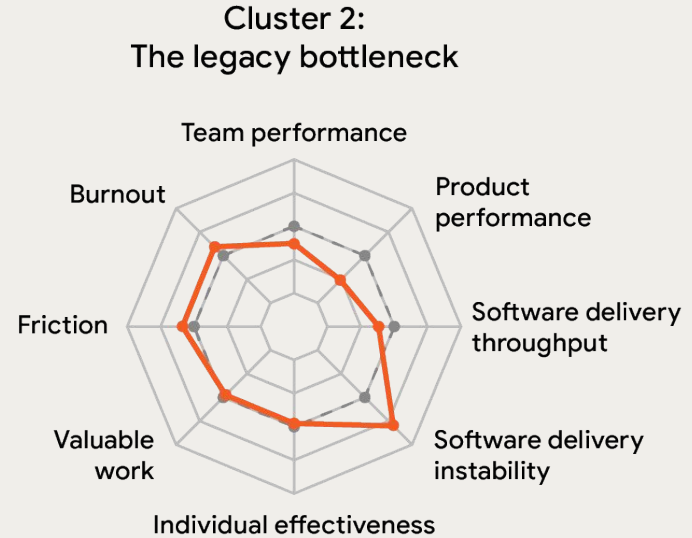
DORA AI Capabilities Model



Legacy bottleneck

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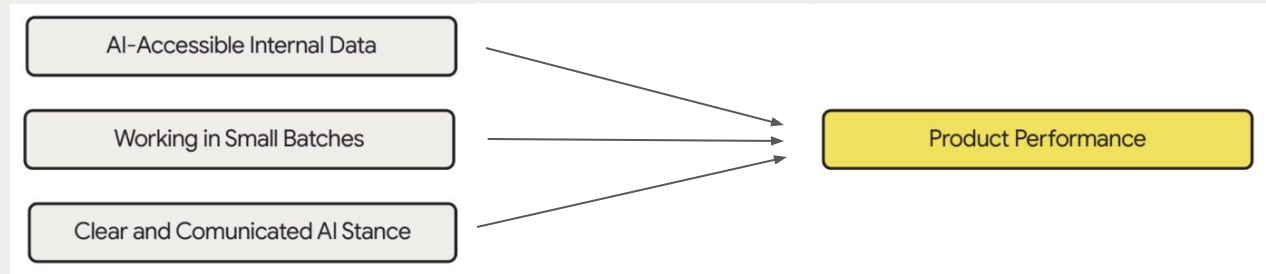


DORA AI Capabilities Model

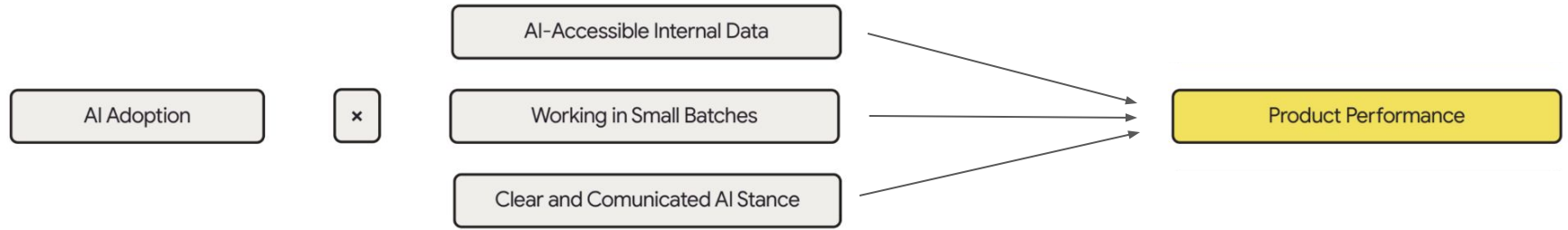
Product Performance

DORA AI Capabilities Model

DORA



DORA AI Capabilities Model



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Jessie Young



Steve Yegge

Research partners

DORA

Google Cloud's DORA team led the research with collaboration from these research partners.



Gene's Hopes And Favorite Findings

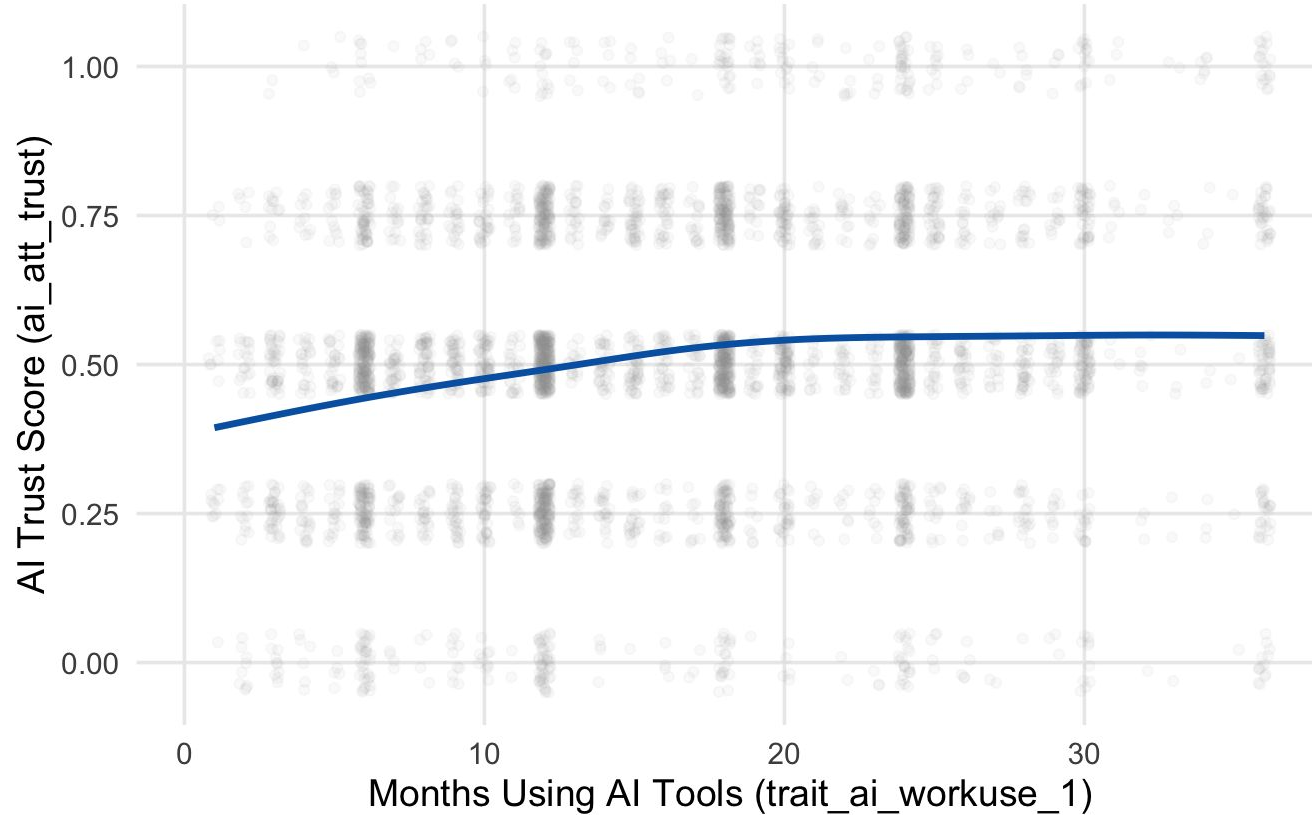
- Hypothesis: AI requires great modular architectures and technical practices
 - The Nyquist stability criterion from control theory tells us that any control system must operate at least twice as fast as the system it controls.
 - Certain activities need to happen more frequently in order to stay in control
 - Version control commits
 - Testing feedback
 - Smaller and decomposed tasks
- Mysteries and inconclusive
 - Larger commits or smaller commits? (Transactional overhead)

Gene's Hopes And Favorite Findings

- Observation: as I've worked with AI more, I trust the AI to do larger tasks
- One strange definition of trust: to what degree do can I predict how another party will act and react — the more I trust the other party, I can make bigger requests, with fewer words, with less feedback
- The notion of *fingerspitzengefühl*: person's instinctive ability to handle complex, uncertain situations with intuition, tact, and sensitivity (thank you Idan Gazit, GitHub)

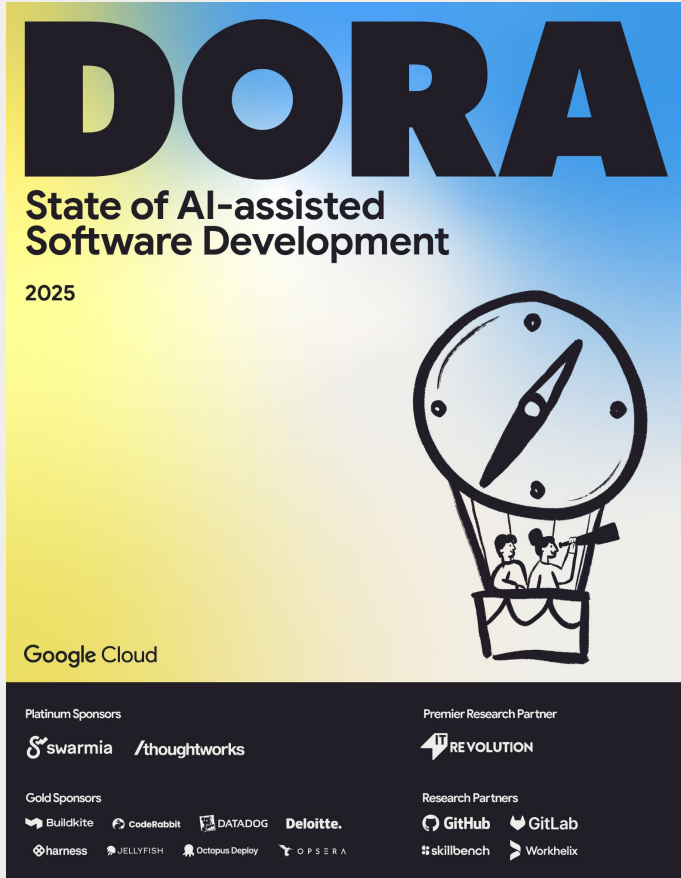
AI Trust Increases With Experience

Trend showing AI Trust Score relative to months using AI tools



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Thank you.